Watercolor Supply Checklist

Everything you actually need to start painting — no fluff, no regrets

I have bought three supply hauls worth of watercolor gear so I could tell you what actually matters. This checklist has been tested by me, walked on by Bruce, and survived a Florida summer on my desk.

1 The Non-Negotiables

- [ ] **Kuretake Gansai Tambi Watercolor Set — 36 Colors**
  Japanese watercolor pans. Creamy, rich, beginner-forgiving. The only paint you need.
- [ ] **Arches 140lb Cold Press Watercolor Paper**
  100% cotton. Holds water like a dream. Do not cheap out here — cheap paper ruins paintings.
- [ ] **Fuumuui Synthetic Watercolor Brush Set**
  Round for detail, bigger round for washes, flat for edges. Holds a sharp point like sable.

2 The Setup Essentials

- [ ] **Large Porcelain Mixing Dish**
  Textured surface so paint does not bead up. White background shows true colors.
- [ ] **Stillman & Birn Beta Series Sketchbook**
  180lb paper. Opens flat. Survives wet-on-wet without buckling.
- [ ] **Washi Tape**
  Peels off cleanly. Tape down paper edges and label your paint wells.
- [ ] **Small Spray Bottle**
  Mist your pans before painting to get them ready. Faster than waiting.

3 What to Skip (For Now)

- [ ] **Masking Fluid**
  Finicky, rips paper, and you can paint around areas carefully instead.
- [ ] **Travel Watercolor Set**
  You will paint at your desk 95% of the time. Save your money.

Quick Tips from My Desk

- Start with just paint + paper. Add brushes next week. Everything else can wait.
- Good paper teaches you. Cheap paper fights you. Splurge on paper if nothing else.
- Keep a paper towel nearby for lifting mistakes while the paint is still wet.
- Paint something you actually like looking at. Flowers are forgiving — no straight lines.

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